

Mediterranean Diet for Arthritis: A 14-Day UK Meal Plan

A practical fortnight meal plan using affordable UK supermarket ingredients, designed to reduce inflammation and support joint health.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-04-07 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Why the Mediterranean Diet Works

The Mediterranean diet is one of the most researched anti-inflammatory eating patterns. Some research suggests that following it consistently may help reduce inflammatory markers such as C-reactive protein (CRP) in people with arthritis, alongside benefits for heart and metabolic health.

Week 1 Overview

Monday: Porridge with walnuts, blueberries and honey / Grilled salmon with roasted

Mediterranean vegetables

Tuesday: Scrambled eggs with spinach on wholegrain toast / Chickpea and sweet potato curry

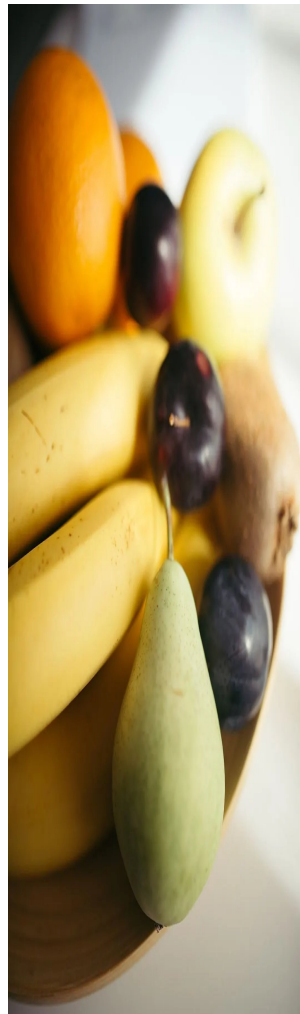
Wednesday: Greek yoghurt with mixed seeds and banana / Turkey and quinoa stuffed peppers

Thursday: Overnight oats with chia seeds and berries / Baked cod with lemon, capers and new potatoes

Friday: Avocado toast with cherry tomatoes / Lentil and vegetable soup with crusty bread

Key Anti-Inflammatory Ingredients - **Extra virgin olive**

oil:** Rich in oleocanthal (acts like ibuprofen)\n-
****Oily fish**:** Salmon, mackerel, sardines (omega-3 fatty acids)\n- ****Colourful vegetables**:** Bell peppers, tomatoes, leafy greens\n- ****Nuts and seeds**:** Walnuts, flaxseeds, almonds\n- ****Herbs and spices**:** Turmeric, ginger, rosemary\n\n### Budget Tips\n- Buy frozen berries and fish (equally nutritious)\n- Use tinned chickpeas, lentils and beans\n- Batch cook soups and curries for the week\n\n*Developed by Registered Dietitian Priya Sharma, BDA*



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What the Evidence Says

Current scientific understanding strongly supports the Mediterranean diet as a valuable approach for managing arthritis symptoms. Systematic reviews of multiple studies consistently show that this eating pattern can help reduce C-reactive protein (CRP) and other markers of inflammation in the body, which are often elevated in people living with inflammatory arthritis.

While the diet isn't a cure, randomised trials have demonstrated its potential to lessen pain, improve physical function, and reduce the need for certain anti-inflammatory medications in some individuals. This positive effect is believed to stem from the diet's abundance of antioxidants, healthy fats, and fibre, which work together to combat inflammation.

Major clinical guidelines for arthritis management often highlight the benefits of a balanced, anti-inflammatory diet, with the Mediterranean approach frequently cited as a prime example. The emphasis is on a long-term dietary shift rather than short-term fixes, focusing on sustainable changes for better joint health.



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Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Expecting instant results:** Give your body time to adapt and for inflammation to settle; stick with it for at least 6-8 weeks to see a difference. * **Focusing only on what to remove:** Instead, concentrate on adding more beneficial foods like vegetables, fruits, and healthy fats. * **Overlooking portion sizes for healthy fats:** Nuts, seeds, and olive oil are good, but still calorie-dense; enjoy them in moderation. * **Not drinking enough water:** Staying well-hydrated is crucial for overall health and to support healthy bodily functions; aim for 6-8 glasses a day. * **Treating it as a strict, restrictive diet:** Think of it as a flexible, enjoyable eating pattern rather than a temporary diet you'll "go off."

When to Speak to a Clinician

While dietary changes can be a helpful part of managing arthritis, they are not a replacement for professional medical advice or prescribed treatments. It's important to talk to your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist if you experience new or worsening symptoms, or if dietary changes aren't making a noticeable difference.



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* Sudden increase in joint pain, swelling, or stiffness. * New or unexplained fatigue, fever, or weight loss. * Symptoms that are severely impacting your daily activities. * Concerns about potential interactions between your diet and medications. * You are considering significant changes to your diet and have underlying health conditions.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I follow this diet if I am vegetarian or vegan? Absolutely. The Mediterranean diet places a strong emphasis on plant-based foods, so it's very suitable for vegetarians and vegans. Focus on plant proteins like chickpeas, lentils, beans, tofu, nuts, and seeds.

Do I need to buy special olive oil? Look for extra virgin olive oil, which is minimally processed and retains more beneficial compounds. You don't need the most expensive brand, but a good quality extra virgin olive oil is key for both flavour and health benefits.

How strict do I need to be with this diet? The Mediterranean diet is more of a lifestyle than a strict regimen. Aim for consistency most of the time, enjoying traditional Mediterranean staples daily, but allow for occasional treats without guilt. It's about sustainable, healthful eating.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about mediterranean diet for arthritis: a 14-day uk meal plan?

Short answer: The Mediterranean diet is one of the most researched anti-inflammatory eating patterns for arthritis. Some research suggests it may help lower inflammatory markers such as CRP. Build meals around olive oil, oily fish, vegetables, wholegrains, legumes, nuts and berries; keep red and processed meats occasional. This 14-day plan turns that pattern into everyday UK meals.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.